The Afterlife of No

Refusal, State Memory, and Serial Continuation in Choice of Romance

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Abstract

What must an interactive romance remember for choosing love to include choosing otherwise? This article examines the publicly accessible first episode of Affairs of the Court: Choice of Romance through close reading, source analysis, and reproducible execution. It distinguishes expressed intention, executable memory, and access to a continuing narrative. A courtship menu offers silence motivated by encouraging pursuit and silence motivated by wanting pursuit to stop; the two options execute identical response prose, score changes, and destinations. In 5,288 paired replays, changing only that selection produces no downstream narrative-state differences. Exhaustive execution of a bounded gift-and-intimacy passage yields 43 terminal choice sequences; repeating these over four observed character configurations and 101 royal relationship-score inputs gives 17,372 executions, all agreeing with an independently written transition model. The passage remembers earlier acceptance of gifts while leaving these motives for silence indistinguishable. A later refusal can stop pursuit, while declining particular intimate acts can increase royal attachment and preserve a path toward marriage. At the episode boundary, some fulfilled nonroyal relationships close the story while royal involvement enables continuation. These findings locate romantic agency across several temporal scales. The article contributes an auditable account of asymmetric refusal memory and a practical method for examining which distinctions between intentions survive narrative implementation, without equating branch counts, relationship scores, or sequel access with experienced freedom.

Keywords: popular romance; interactive fiction; consent mechanics; agency; software studies; serial narrative

1. Choosing love after a refusal

A romance game can give its player a refusal and still leave its meaning unresolved. Declining a gift, declining sex, declining a suitor, and declining to continue a story are different acts. Yet an interface may present them through similar menus, while the narrative assigns them different consequences. The temporal question is what happens after the selection: which intention is remembered, which action is prevented, and which future remains available?

This article addresses that question through Affairs of the Court: Choice of Romance, written by Heather Albano and Adam Strong-Morse and published by Choice of Games. Its first episode places an initially precarious member of a noble family in the marriage politics of a fantasy court. Three major suitors offer different arrangements of attachment, money, and influence. The court's monarch is already married. Family members interpret the protagonist's desirability as a resource for improving their collective position. The work therefore makes choosing love inseparable from choosing among material futures (Albano and Strong-Morse; Choice of Games 2010).

The case is revealing precisely because its alternatives are substantial. The protagonist need not follow the monarch's romance; fulfilled marriages with other suitors are available. The work also permits different protagonist and suitor gender configurations. It would misdescribe this design to declare the player simply powerless. The more productive question concerns the unequal persistence

of particular distinctions: an interface can recognize an intention at the moment of reading without preserving it in the variables that govern later events.

I call this problem asymmetric refusal memory: earlier acceptance and later refusal need not leave equally durable traces in a story's executable representation. The phrase names an interpretive object, rather than a new computational algorithm or a scale of ethical quality. In the focal passage, a remembered acceptance can shape how another refusal is received, while two explicitly different motives for withholding thanks have the same executable afterlife. That combination connects the intimate time of a courtship encounter with the longer time of a serial narrative.

The argument develops through three questions. First, when do differently worded romantic intentions produce the same subsequent narrative state? Second, how does earlier acceptance condition the recognition of a later refusal? Third, how does a completed romance relate to access to the next episode? Close reading establishes the meaning of the alternatives; source inspection establishes their dependencies; execution tests whether the proposed account describes the implementation. None substitutes for the others.

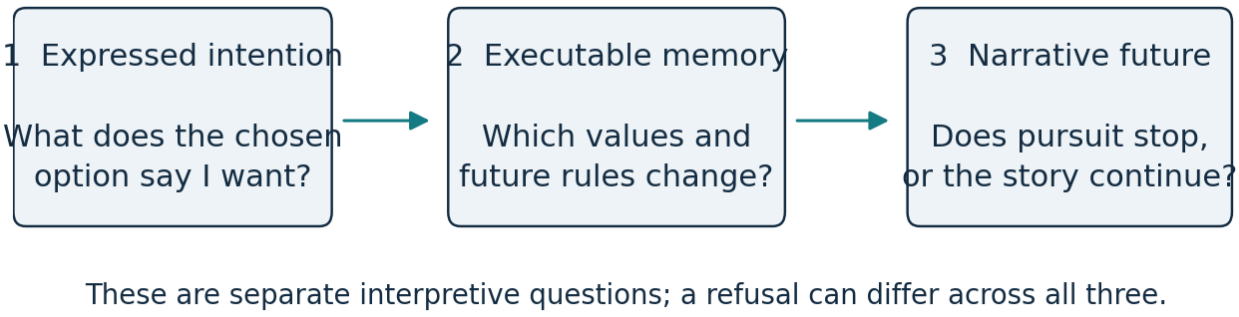


Figure 1. Three objects of analysis. Expressed intention, executable memory, and narrative continuation can diverge. A menu distinction is evidence of an offered interpretation; it does not establish that later story rules preserve that distinction.

2. Romance, consent mechanics, and the limits of counting choices

Popular romance scholarship already treats choice as a contested feature of the genre. Regis's account makes freedom central to the defense of the romance novel, rather than assuming that its conventional ending necessarily confines readers (Regis 2003). Roach describes the genre's reparative work in relation to patriarchal conditions (Roach 2010). These approaches make an optimistic union an occasion for inquiry: what conditions of social life does the fantasy repair, accommodate, or leave in place? A computational reading needs the same specificity. The presence of a marriage ending cannot by itself settle the freedom represented along the route toward it.

Consent within unequal relationships is likewise an established concern. Popova's analysis of arranged-marriage fanfiction examines how changes in the distribution of emotion work can make consent meaningful despite disparities of standing (Popova 2018). Goris situates choice and consent within Nora Roberts's romance fiction (Goris 2012). These studies direct attention to the work and conditions that enable a choice. The present case relocates part of that question into implementation: what does a romance's state model retain about earlier decisions, and what demands does it place on the person trying to decline?

Game scholarship supplies an equally important qualification. Wardrip-Fruin and colleagues understand agency through the relationship between a player's desired actions and a system's supported possibilities, rather than as a synonym for unrestricted action (Wardrip-Fruin et al. 2009). Nguyen and Ruberg's consent mechanics identify the designed interactions through which players can agree to or opt out of experiences (Nguyen and Ruberg 2020). Nguyen's later analysis of sex-technology imaginaries further demonstrates that technical representations of refusal carry cultural assumptions about the access being negotiated (Nguyen 2023). The object here is a fictional protagonist's selectable intention and subsequent narration, not a machine's capacity to grant human sexual consent.

Research on commercial interactive fiction already critiques the economic organization of choice. Kim examines how Choices and Episode organize desirable options around cultural, economic, and temporal resources (Kim 2023). My case concerns a different boundary: a public first episode offers several romantic conclusions, but its continuing serial storyline follows royal involvement. This is a condition of narrative continuity that precedes the purchase decision. It should not be collapsed into a claim that a player can buy consent or that all closure is punitive.

Nor is this the first critical reading of Choice of Romance. Short discusses the work's flexibility of gender and sexuality alongside the uneven involvement in court intrigue available on different paths (Short 2011). Ma's narrative review explicitly considers early completion and the relation between ambition and continuation across the trilogy (Ma 2019). Those observations foreclose a claim to have discovered its uneven narrative lengths. The contribution here is a narrower, executable account connecting the identity of two motive branches, the conditional memory of gift acceptance, and the episode boundary. Existing game verification work also establishes state-based checking and counterexample traces as methods; the present analysis applies ordinary execution and comparison to a literary question (Moreno-Ger et al. 2009).

3. Materials and method

The source corpus is a dated snapshot, retrieved on 16 October 2026, of twelve publicly accessible files served from the publisher's romance/scenes directory. They comprise startup, the first episode's narrative scenes, its wrap-up and preparation files, and the publicly available second-episode transition. Together they contain 351,055 bytes and 5,632 lines. These are source-file measurements, not estimates of word count or the number of player experiences. A manifest records each URL, byte count, line count, and SHA-256 digest. Purchased scenes were outside the corpus. The claim concerns this snapshot; the release history does not establish that every analyzed instruction was present in 2010.

The analysis began with the episode's narrative organization and the relationships among its final scenes, then concentrated on the courtship passage beginning at the Chase label in Marriage.txt. This is purposive case analysis. A distinctive pair of motive options was identified during inspection, so the execution runs are verification and exploration of an observed mechanism, not a preregistered hypothesis test. The entire first episode provides the interpretive context; exhaustive enumeration applies only to the explicitly bounded passage described below.

I use narrative state to mean the current source location and the permanent and temporary values read by the game's subsequent story rules. This definition excludes diagnostic histories and the reader's memory. An option can matter to a reader even when it does not change this state. To call two options narratively state-equivalent is therefore a precise implementation claim, not a judgment that one offers no expressive or interpretive agency.

The execution environment uses the upstream ChoiceScript headless test engine pinned to commit 60a6c3ee7393c9ee7e42650b8e1642ae38e3cb6a. Instrumentation records available option locations, selected source locations, selected scalar snapshots, and terminal values. It disables the upstream heuristic that preferentially explores unused options. Seeds 0 through 9,999 drive 10,000 baseline plays with random choices among the options available at each menu. These are generated executions, not users, and their frequencies are properties of that traversal policy.

The harness copies the public source into a local cache and substitutes a terminal marker for Episode2 only during execution. Arrival there is recorded as reaching the serial boundary; no payment interface or purchased episode is executed. All earlier story files remain byte-identical to the frozen source. Consequently a serial-boundary observation establishes eligibility to continue the story, not successful purchase, an eventual ending, or the value of the sequel. The selected engine is a reproducible implementation of ChoiceScript; this study does not establish a byte-for-byte match with every deployed client.

For the paired intervention, two additional 10,000-play batches use the same seeds and source. At the poem menu alone, the harness selects either withholding thanks to encourage pursuit or withholding thanks to end pursuit. The original random draw at that menu is still consumed, keeping later random draws aligned. The comparison checks the same pre-menu state, all later menu locations and selections, recorded scalar snapshots, terminal boundary, and final scalar values. Before that menu the two batches are identical. Source inspection independently compares the two entire branch bodies after normalizing indentation and blank lines.

For local enumeration, the bounded passage starts at Chase and stops immediately before entry to Mistress, UncleAdvice, or RD. Those labels respectively begin established royal intimacy, consultation about removing the existing spouse, and the return to the season after royal pursuit fails. The interpreter enumerates every available choice sequence within this passage. Four complete character configurations are drawn from observed pre-passage snapshots, one for each combination of the source's binary sex and suitor-pronoun settings. Each is probed with royal relationship-score inputs from 0 to 100, holding its other starting values fixed. The score grid is a sensitivity experiment: not every perturbed state is claimed to be reachable in the complete game.

A separately written Python transition model then predicts the destination, royal relationship score, wealth, reputation, and acceptance-memory flag for every local execution. It implements the visible branches and the engine's integer fairmath rules, including boundary clamping. Agreement checks transcription and execution against each other; it does not independently validate the interpretation of consent. Source assertions, the full instrumented replay specification, scalar traces, local results, and analysis scripts accompany the article.

Check	Scope	Result
Source identity	Two poem branch bodies	Identical after whitespace normalization
Baseline replay	10,000 plays; seeds 0-9,999	5,288 reached the poem menu
Paired intervention	5,288 reached-state pairs	0 downstream mismatches
Local enumeration	43 sequences x 4 profiles x 101 scores	17,372 executions
Independent model	Destinations + 4 checked values	0 disagreements

Table 1. Verification scope and observed results. Execution counts describe the declared harness and state grid; they are not participant counts or prevalence estimates.

4. Two intentions, one executable afterlife

The focal sequence moves through three gifts: a horse, a poem, and jewels. At the poem menu, the protagonist can thank the monarch, remain silent to intensify the monarch's pursuit, or remain silent because the protagonist wants that pursuit to end. The last option is unusually informative because it specifies a motive, rather than merely leaving silence open to interpretation. The two silent options can therefore be distinguished before considering any later outcome (Marriage.txt, lines 1342-1372).

After selection, however, they enact the same response. Both narrate avoidance of the monarch at dinner, both apply the same positive royal relationship update, and both jump to the jewels scene. Neither stores a separate intention-to-end-pursuit value. Their branch bodies are identical after ignoring indentation and blank lines. This is stronger evidence than observing two playthroughs with the same ending: the executable instructions themselves coincide. From their common destination, identical later choices cannot retrieve a distinction that those instructions did not preserve in the story's state.

There is an important limit to this equivalence. The selected option can remain in the reader's memory and in diagnostic choice histories. A person who chooses reluctant silence can understand the next advance as an unwanted continuation; someone choosing strategic silence can understand it as a successful flirtation. The implementation thus offers two readings of the same conduct. The result does not prove an error, authorial negligence, or an absence of expressive agency. It shows that the represented reason for silence has no independent role in subsequent story rules.

The paired replay tests this narrow proposition. The poem menu is reached in 5,288 of the 10,000 seeded initial trajectories. For every one, the intervention changes the selected motive while preserving its pre-menu state. All 5,288 pairs have matching downstream narrative records and final scalar states; they include 27,756 later menu comparisons. The remaining 4,712 seed pairs do not encounter the poem menu and are unchanged. These figures demonstrate reproducibility over reached states. The source identity, rather than a large sample size, supports the general statement about the two branch bodies.

The royal relationship score also requires careful interpretation. Thanking the monarch applies a ten-percent fairmath increase; either silent choice applies twenty percent. At a prior score of 50, these yield 55 and 60. At other scores the difference changes because the increment is proportional to remaining headroom and rounded down. This is not a consent score. The variable tracks the royal relationship and can represent the monarch's increased attachment precisely when the protagonist is

withdrawing. The critical issue is that the story remembers the pursuer's attachment without separately preserving the player's explicitly selected reason for silence.

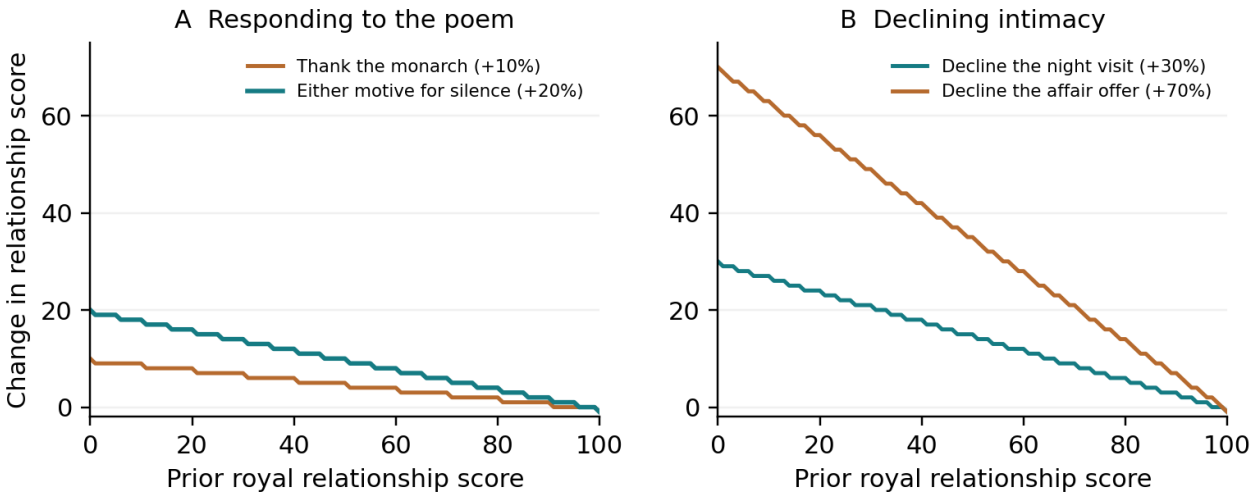


Figure 2. Source-defined changes in the royal relationship score. Positive fairmath uses floor(r + (100 - r)p/100), capped at 99; therefore an input of 100 can fall to 99. Panel A compares gratitude with the two motives for silence. Panel B shows that refusing an intimate invitation or an affair offer can increase royal attachment. These are rule outputs, not inferred feelings or measures of consent.

5. What earlier acceptance makes a later refusal mean

The horse encounter complicates any account in which all refusal is ignored. The protagonist may try to decline the horse, yet the monarch insists and the narration places the protagonist on it. Mechanically, this attempted refusal leaves accepted_something false. Enthusiastically welcoming the gift or accepting it provisionally while consulting the uncle sets that flag true. The source consequently distinguishes physical participation from affirmative reception: riding after an unsuccessful refusal does not count as the acceptance remembered by the later test (Marriage.txt, lines 1301-1340).

The poem can alter that memory. Giving thanks sets the acceptance flag true; either silent option leaves it as it was. The two motives for silence are equivalent, but the sequence is not memoryless. In particular, silence cannot clear an earlier affirmative reception of the horse. The stored value is monotone across these encounters: acceptance can be added, while the offered silent responses do not withdraw it. A single Boolean variable therefore compresses a history of courtship into whether the protagonist has affirmatively received something.

Returning the jewels makes the consequence visible. If accepted_something is false, the narration recognizes the return as ending royal interest and moves to RD. If it is true, returning exactly the same gift leads to a new private offer from the monarch. The state distinction that matters is therefore not whether the protagonist most recently selected a motive of wanting pursuit to end. It is whether earlier conduct set the acceptance flag. Figure 3 shows all nine histories of the horse and poem before the jewels are returned.

The two histories that immediately end pursuit both combine attempted refusal of the horse with silence after the poem. Their motives differ, but their implementation does not. The other seven histories lead to a further royal offer. These nine cells are not equally likely player choices, and seven of nine is not an estimate of a refusal-failure rate. They are the complete Cartesian set of options in those two menus, conditional on returning the jewels. The distinction persists across the declared

relationship-score grid because this routing condition reads the acceptance flag rather than a score threshold.

This arrangement is not a general prohibition on refusal. A player can reach a recognized end to pursuit, and can reject the later offer's proposed form. What it establishes is a particular burden of historical interpretation: the protagonist's earlier reception of attention conditions the meaning assigned to a subsequent rejection. The character's reluctance is available as a present-tense reading before it is available as a durable instruction for the courtship's future. Asymmetric refusal memory identifies that difference without assuming that good romance design must remove every scene of unwanted persistence.

Enumerating the bounded passage yields 43 complete choice sequences to its three stopping labels. Twenty-five lead to Mistress, sixteen to UncleAdvice, and two to RD. Their unequal counts reflect differing numbers of intervening menus, so counting them cannot rank the ethical attractiveness or experienced probability of the destinations. Across four observed character configurations and 101 score inputs, the engine produces 17,372 terminal executions. Every destination and checked numeric value agrees with the independent transition model. The enumeration supports the passage reconstruction; it is not exhaustive verification of the entire episode.

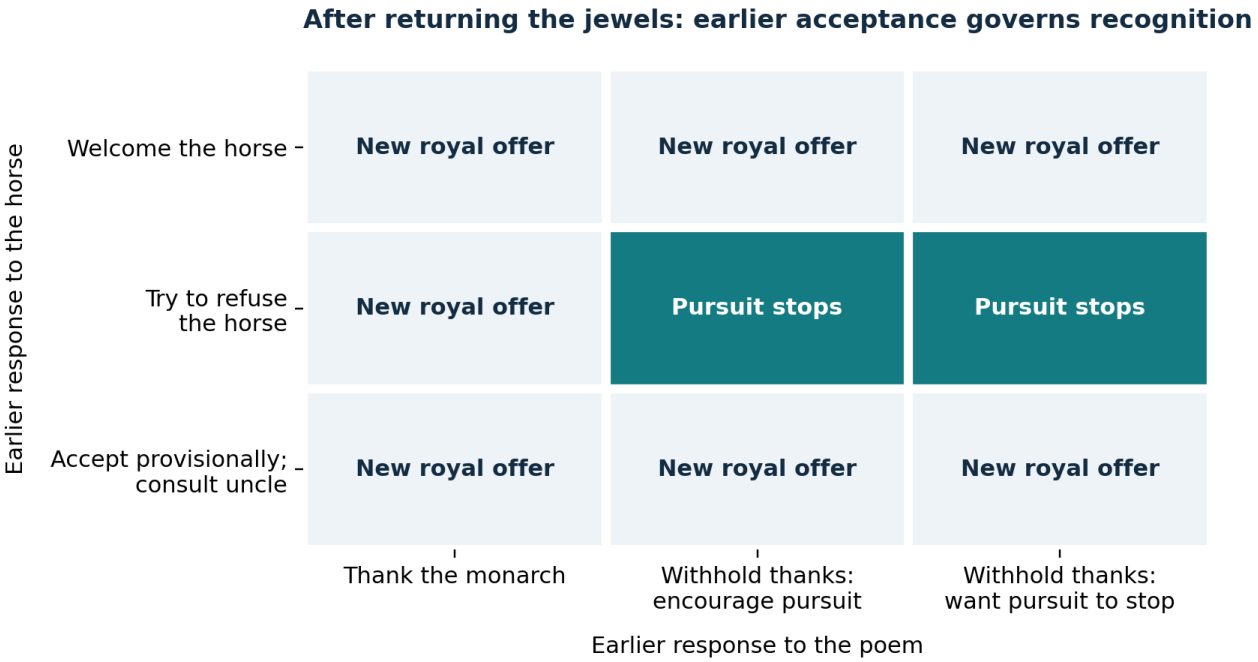


Figure 3. Conditional consequences of returning the jewels. Rows and columns give the earlier horse and poem choices. Only attempted refusal of the horse combined with either motive for silence leaves acceptance memory false, allowing the jewels' return to stop pursuit immediately. Cells enumerate histories; their areas do not represent behavioral probabilities.

6. Refusing an act, choosing a union, ending a story

The invitation that follows accepting the jewels demonstrates why refusal needs an object. Declining a night visit prevents that immediate encounter and leads to a subsequent offer, with a thirty-percent fairmath increase in royal attachment. Declining the proposed affair can instead express the protagonist's willingness to unite with the monarch if the existing marriage were removed. That branch applies a seventy-percent increase and leads to the uncle's advice about discrediting or killing the spouse (Marriage.txt, lines 1404-1510). Reading both choices simply as negative answers would miss what each refuses and what it continues to desire.

The apparent paradox is therefore narratively intelligible: an act-level boundary can coexist with a continuing wish for marriage. The problem is not that every negative answer should stop all romance. It is that the source offers different refusals with very different temporal effects, some of which are visible only by tracing the continuation. A score increase following refusal may depict attachment, calculation, or pursuit; it is insufficient evidence that the rejected act occurred. Here the source explicitly sends the protagonist elsewhere before that encounter takes place.

There is also a third person in the marital future being imagined. The conditional promise of an honorable union directs the protagonist toward the displacement of the monarch's current spouse. The uncle frames that prospect through family advantage and succession. Choosing respectable attachment for the protagonist can thus become a demand to compromise another character's security. This is where Popova's attention to the institutional conditions of consent becomes especially useful: the status of the desired relationship and the distribution of its costs need to be read together. The present interpretation concerns the narrated alternatives; the program cannot decide their moral meaning.

The protagonist may reject the uncle's schemes. That alternative moves to RD, where a disappointing marriage or lonely later life is narrated and the episode ends. This is a particular sequence, not a claim that all refusals produce misery. Elsewhere, the first episode permits satisfying marriage to Torres or Mendosa. The loyal routes for those unions set NoPartTwo and go directly to WrapUp (Proposals.txt, lines 263-282 and 455-468). Romantic fulfillment is therefore genuinely available beyond the royal route, while the continuation of this serial story is organized differently.

The wrap-up makes the distinction explicit: continuing the existing storyline requires a living protagonist who remains romantically involved with the monarch. The Episode2 file then introduces the next installment and its purchase mechanism. Two gates are consequently involved. Narrative eligibility depends on the protagonist's position; acquisition concerns access to the next installment. Paying is not modeled as changing the first gate. A nonroyal romantic closure is not proved to be a bad ending merely because it does not pass through it.

Under the declared random traversal, 4,879 baseline plays reach Episode2 and 5,121 end through WrapUp. The latter include 1,581 Torres closures, 117 Mendosa closures, 279 deaths, and 3,144 other closures. Table 2 reports these as an execution inventory. Menus have unequal numbers of alternatives and paths differ in length; the resulting proportions cannot describe audience preferences, the ease of finding a route, or an author's intended hierarchy. Their value is to demonstrate that the tested corpus actually reaches both serial continuation and nonroyal closure.

What, then, does the serial form ask the reader to choose? A fulfilled private attachment can release a character from further narration. Remaining in the court's unequal field of desire keeps the character available for more story. This can be read as a critique of ambition: the player who continues has refused the sufficiency of an earlier ending. It can also create tension for a reader who wishes to remain with the protagonist while withdrawing from the monarch. The source establishes the gate; these are competing interpretations of what that gate makes possible. Ma's account of early completion and Short's discussion of participation in intrigue make it particularly important to preserve both readings.

Terminal category	Executions	Scope of classification
Serial boundary	4,879	Reached Episode2 before purchase
Torres closure	1,581	WrapUp with marriedTorres true
Mendosa closure	117	WrapUp with marriedMendosa true
Death closure	279	WrapUp with alive false
Other closure	3,144	Remaining WrapUp cases
Total	10,000	All baseline plays

Table 2. Baseline execution inventory, seeds 0-9,999. Categories are mutually exclusive within the harness and describe its terminal flags and boundary. Counts reflect random traversal, not real play or normative rankings of endings.

7. From interpretation to an authoring practice

The practical contribution is a way to make a narrative design decision reviewable. An author or editor can identify an option whose wording claims a motive, specify which future distinctions should depend on that motive, and inspect whether the source retains enough information to make those distinctions. A paired replay changes that option alone, keeping earlier circumstances and later choices fixed. Where the resulting states coincide, the team can decide whether the equivalence is expressive design, intentional dramatic constraint, or an implementation that defeats the intended experience.

A useful specification separates three questions: should this act happen, should this relationship remain open, and should some story continue? Each may have a different answer. An author can intentionally depict a persistent pursuer while preserving the protagonist's refusal in later narration. A romance can close one relationship while continuing a political or friendship plot. A character can withdraw from an act without committing to the end of a relationship. These possibilities do not demand that every choice create a wholly new route, or that difficult romantic fantasies become unavailable.

For commercial interactive-fiction production, the immediate application is quality assurance for script revisions and localization. A translated option can become more categorical than its source while retaining the same state update. A revision can preserve dialogue but change which later events are reachable. The released replay harness and source assertions illustrate tests a studio could adapt to its own declared narrative intentions. They do not constitute an evaluated product, a market-size estimate, a proven retention intervention, or a claim to patentability. Their potential value is the traceable link between a wording decision and its downstream implementation.

There is also a methodological benefit for romance scholarship. Source analysis can distinguish a silence chosen to encourage pursuit from a silence chosen to withdraw, even when a recorded playthrough shows the same visible action. Conversely, execution prevents a critic from attributing different programmatic effects to those motives merely because their menu labels differ. A productive computational contribution is thus to make the scope of an interpretation inspectable, while leaving cultural judgment and the meaning of pleasure open to argument.

8. Scope and limitations

This is one source-based case study of a dated, publicly accessible episode. It supports analytical transfer to other works, rather than a prevalence claim about romance games. The corpus excludes purchased installments, other client versions, adaptation histories, localization, and audience reception. Its binary character parameters also limit what the sensitivity experiment can establish about gender. The four observed configurations provide coherent starting profiles for mechanical comparison; they do not establish equivalent social meanings for all represented relationships.

The focal pair was selected because its alternatives were conspicuously different in motive and identical in execution. That selection is appropriate for explaining a mechanism but cannot establish how often the game collapses such distinctions. Random traversal verifies reached examples and can miss rare states. The exact argument is confined to the identical branch bodies and their common continuation; the exhaustive experiment is confined to the bounded passage. Diagnostic records and a reader's changing interpretation remain distinct from the narrative state compared here.

Finally, computational equivalence is not ethical equivalence. Opposite motives can legitimately produce the same social response, especially in a story about asymmetric power. An interface can offer an expressive distinction without promising a distinct branch. The strongest supported conclusion is that the work distributes different kinds of recognition across different timescales. Whether a given reader finds that distribution pleasurable, disturbing, or politically illuminating requires evidence beyond these executions.

9. Conclusion

Choosing love in interactive romance is partly a choice about what the narrative will remember. In this episode, the protagonist can select different reasons for silence, but the subsequent rules preserve the monarch's growing attachment rather than that difference of motive. A later rejection of jewels can end pursuit only under a particular history of prior reception. Other refusals preserve the desired union while changing its conditions. At the serial boundary, some fulfilled romances release the protagonist from the story, while continued royal involvement opens another installment.

These are distinct consequences of refusal, established by a combination of close reading, source identity, paired replay, and bounded enumeration. Asymmetric refusal memory offers a name for the unequal durability of the choices involved. It also suggests a question for further comparative work: when a romance asks someone to choose connection, which earlier expressions of willingness or reluctance remain available to shape the future that connection promises?

Data and code availability

The reproducibility repository contains the source manifest, acquisition and instrumentation scripts, compressed scalar replay traces, the independent transition model, local execution results, figures, and manuscript source: https://github.com/shi1720/refusal-afterlives. The game's copyrighted narrative and the upstream engine are acquired separately from their respective sources and are not relicensed by this repository. A reproduction checks source hashes before proceeding. Source references in this article use one-based line numbers in the frozen files, with original option labels located by the manifest and scripts.

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